There was also a change in attitude toward India within the administration, which was reluctant to prop up Jiang, whose loss seemed imminent. At the end of August, Truman noted that India had now become "key to the whole Asian situation." Two years after the CIA report had put India in the least-important category, reports in September 1949 from the agency and State Department intelligence highlighted India's importance as the only potential competitor to China in Southeast Asia.[18] A State Department consultative committee on Asia advocated American support for potentially stable, independent governments and noted that "India and particularly Nehru" were "the most solid element with which the United States can associate itself."[19] The US ambassador to Moscow added that instead of wasting resources trying to take on the communists in China, the US should build up countries like India and Japan "where we still have [a] good chance [to] stem [the] Communist tide."[20]

Thus, by the time Nehru landed in Washington in October 1949, India had been assigned a role in the US strategic framework—a role that was highly derivative of that of China. This came with benefits. The press declared Nehru to be the "number one man in Asia" and the "strongest figure in a troubled continent." India was "potentially a great counterweight to China."[21] *Time* put Nehru on its cover and declared India the "anchor for Asia."[22] Along with public adulation, Robert J. McMahon has argued that India's new value also "led a growing number of administration strategists to accept India's intransigence [on issues like Kashmir] with equanimity."[23]

The "fall" of China also ensured that Indian economic aid requests were given "a more thorough hearing" in Washington. In the early years of Indian independence, the US had either ignored or rejected most aid requests from Delhi because policymakers had not seen assistance to India as "significantly advanc[ing]" American interests. But by early October 1949, US ambassador to India and committed cold warrior Loy Henderson was proposing a five-year, $500 million economic assistance package for the country. The basis that he laid out for Washington was that India could become "a stalwart and worthy champion in Asia."[24]

Not everyone in the Truman administration shared this enthusiasm. For example, Raymond Hare, the deputy assistant secretary of state for the Near East and South Asia, was skeptical about India's ability to play the role envisioned. Others, such as the Far Eastern Affairs director, W. W.